

1 Part One: The Building

1.1 The Reading Room

1.1.1 Light

1.1.1.1 Direct Sunlight

Direct sun is the enemy a reading room is built to exclude. It fades pigment, yellows paper, and warps the boards of a binding within a single summer if a book is left in its path. Desks are therefore turned away from the windows that admit it, and the shelves retreat from the glass entirely. The light a reader needs and the light a book can survive are not the same light, and the room is a compromise struck between them.

1.1.1.2 Indirect Light

A clerestory window, set high in the wall and turned from the noon arc, spills an even and indirect light onto the desk while sparing the shelves the worst of the heat. It is the oldest answer to the lighting problem and it remains the best. A room lit this way needs no lamp until dusk, and the manuscripts shelved in it are spared the slow damage that a sunlit room inflicts without anyone noticing.

1.1.2 Air

Still air lets mould settle and spores take hold; air that moves too briskly dries bindings unevenly and lifts dust from every surface into the reader's breath. The aim is a slow, steady exchange that no one in the room can feel. Ventilation is judged a success precisely when it is imperceptible, which makes it one of the hardest systems in the building to tune and the easiest to neglect.

1.2 The Stacks

1.2.1 Shelving

A book belongs upright, supported by its neighbours, bearing its weight on its boards and never on the fragile edges of its pages. A shelf filled only halfway lets its books lean, and a leaning book deforms under its own weight over years until the spine no longer sits square. A block placed at the end of

a short row holds the books vertical and costs nothing but the discipline to use it.

1.2.2 Climate

Cool and dry preserves; warm and damp destroys. The exact figures matter less than their steadiness, for a collection suffers more from a climate that swings than from one held at a slightly wrong but constant value. Materials expand and contract as conditions move, and it is the movement, repeated season after season, that loosens joints and cracks leather. A stable wrong number is kinder than a correct average reached by veering above and below it.

2 Part Two: The Collection

2.1 Handling

2.1.1 Hands

Clean, dry hands serve a book better than cotton gloves, which dull the sense of touch and catch on the very paper they are meant to protect. A reader who can feel the page turns it with the right amount of force and no more. The instinct to reach for gloves is understandable, but for ordinary paper it trades a real benefit for an imagined one.

2.1.2 Supports

An open book should rest in a cradle that holds its two boards at a gentle angle, so that the spine is never forced to lie flat. A binding opened flat on a hard table is being asked to bend in a direction it was never built to bend, and each such opening spends a little of the life left in the spine. The cradle is not a courtesy to the book; it is a condition of consulting it without harm.

2.2 Repair

2.2.1 Reversibility

2.2.1.1 Adhesives

Every adhesive introduced in a repair must be removable by a later conservator without harm to the page beneath it. A repair that cannot be undone is not a repair but damage deferred, because it forecloses the choices of everyone who handles the book afterward. The conservator works in materials chosen as much for how cleanly they come away as for how well they hold.

2.2.1.2 Documentation

Each repair is recorded in plain terms: what was done, with which materials, and on what date. The note outlives the conservator who wrote it and speaks directly to whoever opens the book next, perhaps a century on. An undocumented repair leaves that future reader guessing whether a feature of the book is original or an intervention, and the guess can go wrong in either direction.

2.2.2 Knowing When to Stop

The most disciplined repair is often the one not attempted at all. A book that is stable, even if visibly worn, is frequently best left exactly as it is, because every intervention carries its own small risk and its own loss of original material. A conservator's restraint is as much a skill as any technique of the hand, and it is the harder skill to teach, since it shows only in the work not done.